same period. Domestic production, by contrast, has remained nearly constant. In February, agriculture minister Chouhan acknowledged that "importing pulses is a matter of shame for us".

There are many reasons for the sorry state of affairs. As high-yield wheat and rice spread over the landscape, pulses nearly disappeared from many states, including Punjab, says Dr Vibha Dhawan, director general of The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) in New Delhi. Policy bias also skewed research investment, says Dinesh Chand Meena, senior scientist at ICAR–National Institute of Agricultural Economics and Policy Research in New Delhi. As a result, he says, yield per hectare grew only 88 per cent for pulses over 1980-2021, compared to 148 per cent for cereals.

What causes these gaps? Ramanjaneyulu calls it an "institutional failure" and cites a stark fact: 99 per cent of research and development in pulse seeds in India is a public sector activity. Put that under a microscope and the usual broken links show up. Dr Girish Prasad Dixit, director at ICAR-Indian Institute of Pulses Research in Kanpur, says scientists are responsible for the first two stages: the nucleus seed and its progeny, the breeder seed. Multiplying that first into foundation seeds, and then certified seeds for commercial distribution, is the job of state agencies. Unsurprisingly, that's where the chain breaks.

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Changing the Dal Moment

Imports, price controls or one more seasonal procurement announcement, experts say, cannot solve India's pulses conundrum. What can is treating it as a protein-security mission. The Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses launched by the Centre in October 2025 with an outlay of Rs 11,440 crore targets 35 MT production by 2030. It promises 100 per cent state procurement of tur, urad and masoor at MSP for four years. Nearly 20 million farmers are expected to benefit. But the path ahead is tricky. Three similar interventions in the 2004-14 period failed to bear fruit, having focused more on productivity and area.

A paucity of high-yield varieties still forms a key part of the riddle, as a 2025 NITI Aayog report conceded. India's pulse yield is still around 925 kg per hectare; it must be pushed to 1,150 kg per ha through better seeds, climate-resilient varieties, pest control, extension and technology. ICAR-IIPR has identified 233 of 421 pulse-growing districts as below the national average. That micro-level diagnosis must now move from research papers to district action plans, with state agencies ensuring that newer varieties of tur, urad, masoor, moong and chana reach farmers.



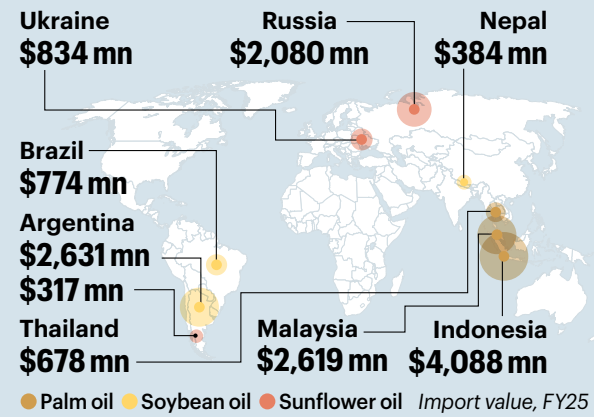
CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

EDIBLE OILS

IMPORT SOURCES

FOREIGN FLOW

Major edible oils consumed in India originate from a handful of countries



The second reset must be in incentives. India built food security by rewarding rice and wheat; it must now build nutritional security by rewarding pulses. Pulses also use less water and fix nitrogen in the soil, yet the farmer growing them receives far less policy attention than the farmer growing water-guzzling paddy. Experts such as Vibha Dhawan argue that government spending on malnutrition should be linked to incentives for farmers who grow nutritionally dense pulses. MSP support for pulses must, therefore, be deemed as credible as it